ABITUR ENGLISH · WRITING

outline · summarize · sum up

+ point out · describe

How to give a concise account of the main points

> **WHAT DO "OUTLINE", "SUMMARIZE" AND "SUM UP" MEAN?**
>
> *"give a concise account of the main points or ideas of a text, issue or topic as specified by the task"*

Dos and don'ts

DO	DON'T
✓ only the **aspect the task asks for**	× cover everything the text says
✓ **all main points** of this aspect	× details (numbers, names, examples, quotations) – unless the task needs them
✓ **your own words**	× copy phrases from the text
✓ **simple present** (also for stories)	× past tense as the basic tense
✓ neutral: what the **text** says	× your opinion, analysis, a final comment
✓ group points by **aspects**, link them	× retell the text paragraph by paragraph

Step by step

Model task: **Outline the reasons for the popularity of digital detox camps and the criticism they face.**

STEP	WHAT TO DO	MODEL TASK (text on page 3)
① Read the task	Underline the **focus** of the task. Several parts (*and*, *also referring to*)? Each part needs an answer.	**Two parts:** the reasons for the camps' popularity **and** the criticism they face.
② Mark the text	Mark every passage that belongs to the focus. Ignore what does not belong to it.	Reasons: parents, teenagers, schools. Criticism: psychologists and others. The camp itself and the outlook: not asked for.
③ Reduce	Note each main point in a few key words. Leave out examples, numbers, names and quotations (unless central). Combine points that say the same thing.	Reasons: parents' worries about well-being · relief from being always reachable, more real contact · better concentration. Criticism: no lasting change · high price · better: sensible use in everyday life
④ Write	Optional: one short opening sentence (title, author, focus). One or two sentences per main point, linked with connectives. Own words, simple present, neutral, formal (no *I*). No fixed length, no conclusion or final comment.	*The article … deals with … First of all, … Furthermore, … However, critics …*
⑤ Check	Every main point there? Nothing extra? No final comment? Simple present as the basic tense? No opinion, no quotation?	Both parts answered; no names, prices or final comment.

Typical tasks in the Abitur

- *Outline the origin and the general concept of Silent Book Clubs, also referring to the Melbourne chapter.* (2026, gA)
- *Outline what the text reveals about Lara, her lifestyle, and her attitude towards it.* (2026, gA)
- *Outline the development of the Rockaway Beach Branch and the plans for its future use.* (2026, eA)

→ Most tasks have **two or three parts** – answer every part.

Useful phrases

Opening sentence (optional)	Einleitungssatz (optional)
The article "…" **by** …, **published in** … **on** …, **deals with** …	Der Artikel „…" von …, erschienen in … am …, behandelt …
The excerpt from the novel "…" **by** … **focuses on** …	Der Auszug aus dem Roman „…" von … konzentriert sich auf …
The text presents several reasons why …	Der Text nennt mehrere Gründe, warum …
Reporting what the text says	**Wiedergeben, was der Text sagt**
The author points out / explains / emphasizes / argues that …	Der Autor weist darauf hin / erklärt / betont / argumentiert, dass …
According to the text, …	Dem Text zufolge …
The author claims / states that …	Der Autor behauptet / stellt fest, dass …
The text mentions … / **The author refers to** …	Der Text erwähnt … / Der Autor bezieht sich auf …
Linking the main points	**Hauptpunkte verbinden**
First of all, … / **To begin with**, …	Zunächst …
Furthermore / **In addition** / **Moreover**, …	Darüber hinaus / Außerdem …
Another reason / aspect is that …	Ein weiterer Grund / Aspekt ist, dass …
Apart from …, …	Abgesehen von … / Neben …
Finally, … / **Above all**, …	Schließlich … / Vor allem …
Cause, effect and contrast	**Grund, Folge und Gegensatz**
As a result, … / **This is why** …	Infolgedessen … / Deshalb …
because of … / **due to** …	wegen … / aufgrund von …
However, … / **While** …, …	Jedoch … / Während …
Fictional texts: characters	**Literarische Texte: Figuren**
The text reveals that X …	Der Text zeigt, dass X …
We learn that X … / X **is presented as** …	Wir erfahren, dass X … / X wird als … dargestellt
X **seems to feel** … / X **is described as** …	X scheint … zu empfinden / X wird als … beschrieben
The narrator describes how …	Der Erzähler beschreibt, wie …

AVOID

× *In the text it says …*	× *The author tells that …*	× *The text is about …*
✓ *According to the text, …*	✓ *The author states that …*	✓ *The text deals with …*
× *The author explained …*	× *"I wanted her to remember …"*	× *cleverly, of course, I think*
✓ *The author explains …*	✓ *parents want their children to …*	✓ neutral, no opinion

RELATED OPERATORS – WHAT IS DIFFERENT?

OPERATOR	DEFINITION	COMPARED WITH OUTLINE
point out	*"present the main aspects of sth. briefly"*	Like *outline*: only the main aspects, **briefly** – but still complete and in full sentences.
describe	*"give a detailed account of what sb./sth. is like"*	**More detail** about what a person, place, situation or picture is like (appearance, behaviour, atmosphere) – relevant details are welcome. Still no analysis, no opinion.

Model solution

MODEL TEXT (INVENTED FOR PRACTICE · LEVEL B2/C1)

Unplugged: Why Teenagers Are Paying to Lose Their Phones – Rachel Hughes, *The Northbridge Review*, 14 June 2026

Every summer, a growing number of British teenagers hand over their smartphones at the gate of a converted farm in rural Wales and do not see them again for ten days. What sounds like a punishment has become one of the fastest-growing segments of the holiday market: digital detox camps, which promise young people a break from the constant pull of notifications, likes and streaks.

For many parents, the decision is driven by anxiety. Surveys repeatedly link heavy social media use to sleep problems, low self-esteem and the feeling of being permanently compared with others. “My daughter could not sit through a meal without checking her phone,” says one mother from Bristol. “I wanted her to remember what boredom feels like.”

Interestingly, it is not only parents who are making the bookings. Camp organisers report that an increasing number of teenagers book places themselves. Many describe the relief of no longer having to be available around the clock. Without screens, they say, conversations last longer, friendships form more quickly, and activities such as hiking or cooking together suddenly feel rewarding rather than tedious.

Some schools have begun to take notice, too, and send whole classes before the summer holidays. Teachers who have accompanied groups claim that students return with noticeably better concentration and are more willing to tackle demanding tasks without immediate rewards – a quality that, as one head teacher puts it, “no app can teach”.

Critics, however, remain sceptical. Psychologists warn that a short, radical break rarely changes habits in the long term; once the teenagers are back home, old routines tend to return within days. Others object to the price tag of up to £1,500, which turns a healthy relationship with technology into a privilege for the well-off. Instead of sending children away, they argue, families and schools should teach responsible use in everyday life.

For now, demand shows no signs of slowing down. Whether the camps offer a genuine cure or merely an expensive pause button may only become clear years from now.

Outline the reasons for the popularity of digital detox camps and the criticism they face.

The labels show the main points; phrases from page 2 are in **bold**.

OPENING	**The article** “Unplugged: Why Teenagers Are Paying to Lose Their Phones” **by** Rachel Hughes **deals with** digital detox camps for teenagers, which are becoming increasingly popular but are also criticized.
REASON 1	**First of all**, many parents are concerned that spending too much time on social media harms their children’s health and well-being, and they want them to experience everyday life without their phones.
REASON 2	**Furthermore**, more and more teenagers sign up on their own initiative because they enjoy not having to be reachable all the time and find it easier to connect with others offline.
REASON 3	**In addition**, schools are showing growing interest: **according to** teachers who have taken part, students come back more focused and more patient with difficult tasks.
CRITICISM 1	**However**, psychologists doubt that such a brief time offline has a lasting effect, as most participants soon fall back into their former habits at home.
CRITICISM 2	**Moreover**, other critics **point out that** the camps are so expensive that only wealthy families can afford them. Instead, they suggest that parents and teachers should help young people learn to use their devices sensibly in daily life.

LEFT OUT – AND WHY

- The description of the camp (farm in Wales, ten days) and the outlook at the end: **not asked for**.
- Bristol, £1,500, the surveys in detail: **details** – “expensive” is enough.
- Examples (the meal, hiking, cooking): **details**.
- All quotations: rewritten in **your own words** or left out.